

Reference Letter — CCCW Postdoctoral Fellowship (Ref. 535079)

Recommender: Professor Xiulan Zhang, Beijing Normal University

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[Date]

Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I write in strong support of Dr. Mengnan Xu’s application for the Postdoctoral Fellow position at the Centre on Contemporary China and the World. I have supervised Ms. Xu since 2016 — through her Master of Public Management and into her doctoral research — and I am in an unusually well-placed position to assess both the quality of her scholarship and the depth of her commitment to the study of Chinese governance.

Ms. Xu’s doctoral dissertation examines the impact of China’s Targeted Poverty Alleviation program on long-term household development and vulnerability to poverty relapse, using seven waves of CFPS panel data spanning 2010 to 2022. The methodological design is rigorous: she applies staggered difference-in-differences estimation and a three-stage least squares vulnerability procedure to separate program effects from selection and to quantify prospective downward risk — not merely whether households escaped poverty, but whether policy exposure reduced their exposure to future poverty. The dissertation passed blind external review and is scheduled for oral defense in May 2026. It represents, in my assessment, a serious contribution to the causal evaluation of large-scale state welfare programs in China.

Alongside the dissertation, Ms. Xu has worked closely with me on two collaborative research projects that address the organizational architecture through which China’s poverty alleviation governance operates. Our joint work proposes the concept of a “development governance knowledge system” — a model of state-led multi-actor coordination integrating government agencies, enterprises, universities, and financial institutions — that departs structurally from the NGO-centered frameworks common in international development research. A second working paper develops a replicable computational pipeline for analyzing Chinese governance documents at scale. These projects draw directly on original data infrastructure that Ms. Xu has constructed under my supervision: a multi-actor coordination database documenting government, enterprise, and social organization participation in poverty alleviation from 2010 to 2023, and a social organization database covering over 2,000 organizations with approximately 26 months of longitudinal data on funding flows and project activity. These datasets did not exist in the field before this work; their construction required sustained initiative, methodological judgment, and the ability to integrate heterogeneous sources across a decade of policy implementation. Ms. Xu designed and led this work independently.

Ms. Xu’s computational capabilities are a genuine asset. During her earlier appointment on a Gates Foundation-funded research program at Beijing Normal University, she applied natural language processing pipelines — including topic modeling and named-entity recognition — to Chinese-language policy corpora exceeding 10,000 documents. She subsequently spent nearly a year as a software engineer on Apple’s Intelligence platform, where she worked on production-scale NLP pipelines and retrieval-augmented generation architectures. This experience is not incidental to her research profile. It means she brings to social science questions an engineer’s understanding of

how large language models process and structure documentary evidence — and, critically, where they introduce systematic errors that require scholarly correction. At a moment when AI methods are becoming central to governance research, this combination of domain expertise and technical capability is rare among scholars at her career stage.

CCCW's dual focus on Chinese political leadership and governance and on AI methods for social science aligns directly with the research agenda Ms. Xu has developed. The organizational ecology database she has built provides the empirical foundation for precisely the kind of sub-national governance analysis that complements macro-level leadership research. Her first-authored publication in the *Journal of Contemporary China* (2022, SSCI Q1) demonstrates her capacity to produce independent, peer-reviewed research on Chinese politics and society. She also has the linguistic fluency — native Mandarin, proficient academic English — and the collaborative experience, having worked across government, university, and foundation settings, to contribute effectively to CCCW's research environment.

I recommend Ms. Xu without reservation. The quality of her dissertation, the originality of the databases she has constructed, and the methodological range she brings to questions of Chinese governance make her, in my view, an exceptionally strong candidate for this fellowship.

Sincerely,

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